

DECODED

EXPLAINED

13th September 2026

In Backdrop of Handshake, a Cultural Keynote — Rameshwaram Temple

In backdrop of handshake, a cultural keynote — Rameswaram temple

Divya A

New Delhi, September 12

THE 12TH-CENTURY Ramanathaswamy Temple in Rameswaram, Tamil Nadu, served as the visual backdrop and cultural centerpiece when PM Narendra Modi welcomed world leaders at Bharat Mandapam for the BRICS Leaders' Summit in New Delhi on Saturday, highlighting India's civilisational history to the Global South.

It was against this backdrop that the day's first handshake happened between PM Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping, with the two leaders spending sometime looking at the 3D backdrop, and PM Modi explaining the site to the Chinese President. Tamil Nadu is also where Modi had hosted Xi during his last India visit in 2019.

The temple in Rameswaram is among the 12 sacred Jyotirlingas.

gas. Its outer corridor — displayed in the image at Bharat Mandapam — is the longest among all temples in India, featuring over 1,200 intricately carved stone pillars.

As dignitaries walked the red carpet to the spot where the PM welcomed them, there were murals depicting 'yogasanas'. At the summit venue, artists from BRICS member countries have created 'Sangam' — a mural depicting the Summit logo at the centre, with the image of the iconic Hawa Mahal of Jaipur, flanked by a pair of elephants.

According to a Tamil Nadu government website, the Ramanathaswamy Temple was under the care of a monk up to the 10th century. In the 12th century, Parakiramabaghu, the King of Ceylon, built the sanctum sanctorum of the temple. Three hundred years later, Ramanathapuram King Udayan



(Left) PM Narendra Modi explains to Chinese President Xi Jinping the architectural wonders of Rameswaram temple, at Bharat Mandapam on Saturday; (above) the leaders in Mamallapuram in 2019. PTI

Sethupathi and a Vaisya from Nagoore built its western tower and compound walls.

Subsequently, between 1897 and 1904, the 126-foot-high nine-tiered East Rajagopuram was completed by the family of Nattukkottai. According to Hindu mythology, Lord Ram consecrated the shivalingam here after returning from Lanka.

Earlier, during India's G20 Presidency in 2023, a replica of the Konark Wheel from Odisha's Sun Temple served as the primary backdrop for Modi's welcome handshakes with global leaders. It was chosen to represent India's ancient heritage, wisdom, and advanced civilisation, with Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam as the G20 theme.

In Backdrop of Handshake, a Cultural Keynote — Rameshwaram Temple

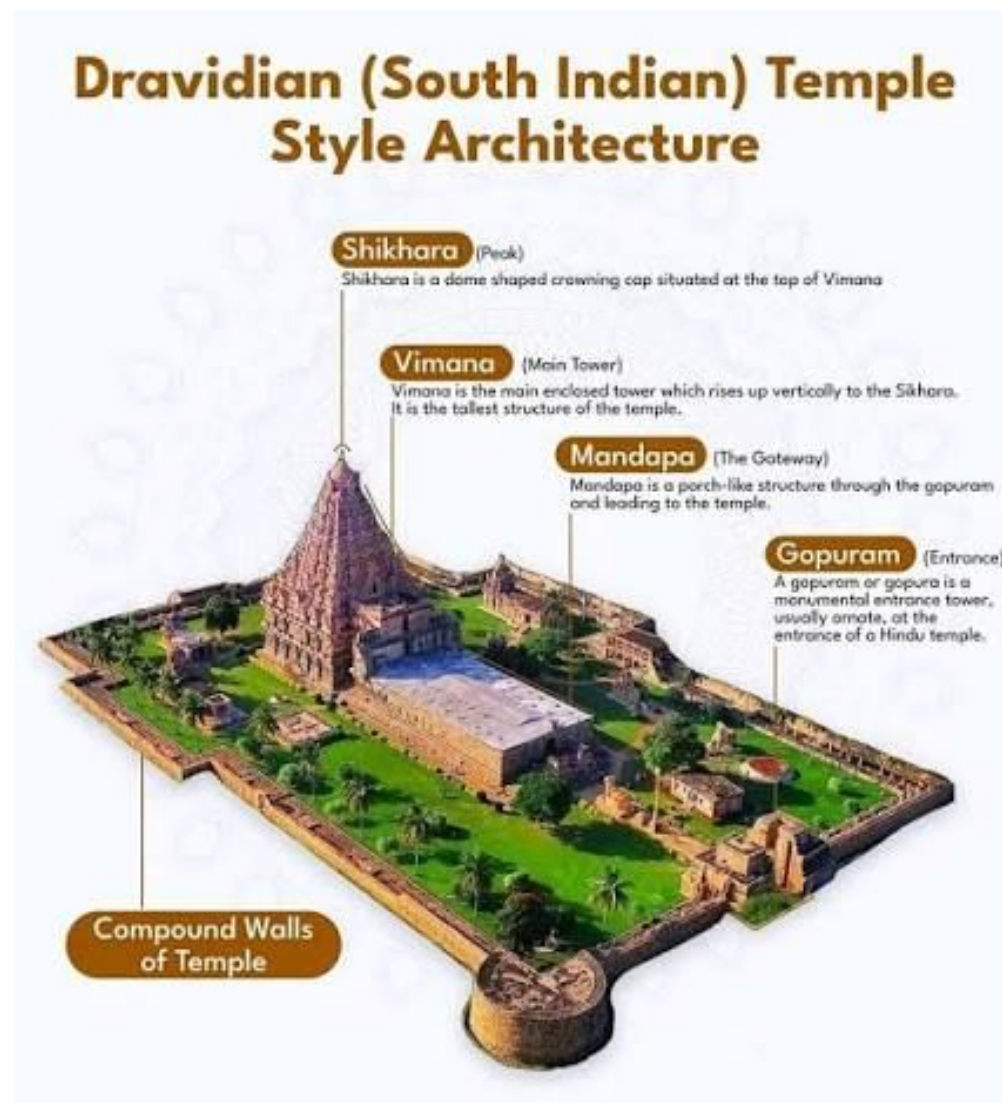
Ramanathaswamy Temple

- The **12th-century temple** is dedicated to Lord Shiva.
- **Location:** Rameswaram island, Tamil Nadu
- It is counted among the **12 sacred Jyotirlingas** in the Hindu belief system.
- **Sacred Mythology:** Believed to be established by Lord Rama, who consecrated a lingam of sand (Ramalingam) to worship Lord Shiva upon returning from Lanka.
- **Evolution of Structure:** Managed by ascetic monks until the 10th century; the inner sanctum was constructed in the 12th century by **King Parakramabahu of Sri Lanka (Ceylon).**
- **Patronage of the Sethupathis & Nagarathars:** Extensively expanded from the 15th to 18th centuries by the Sethupathi kings of Ramanathapuram. The 126-foot-high, nine-tiered East Rajagopuram was completed between 1897 and 1904 by the AL. AR. Nagarathar family of Devakottai.

In Backdrop of Handshake, a Cultural Keynote — Rameshwaram Temple

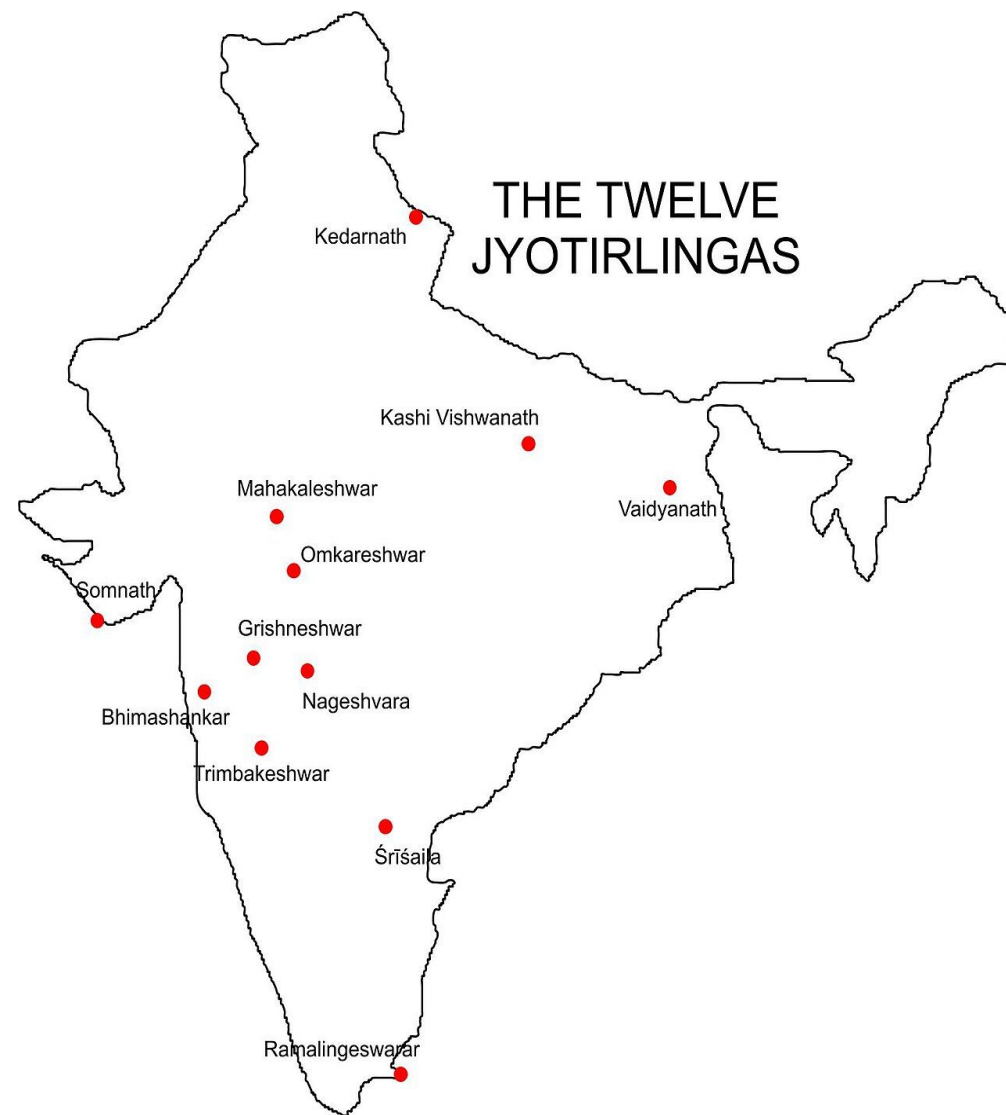
It has been built in Dravidian style :

- The Dravida temple is enclosed within a compound wall.
- The front wall has an entrance gateway in its centre, which is known as a Gopuram.
- The shape of the main temple tower known as vimana in Tamil Nadu is like a stepped pyramid that rises up geometrically rather than the curving shikhara of North India.
- It is common to find a large water reservoir, or a temple tank, enclosed within the complex.



In Backdrop of Handshake, a Cultural Keynote : Rameshwaram Temple

1. Kedarnath on the banks of Mandakini river
2. Kashi Vishwanath on the west bank of the Ganga
3. Vaidyanath (Baidyanath) : Deoghar, Jharkhand in the Santal Parganas region
4. Mahakaleshwar Ujjain, Madhya Pradesh on the Shipra (Kshipra) river. South-facing (Dakshinmukhi) Jyotirlinga among the twelve.
5. Omkareshwar : Mandhata Island, Narmada river, Madhya Pradesh. The island on which the temple stands is shaped like the sacred symbol 'Om'.
6. Somnath : Prabhas Patan, Gir Somnath district, Gujarat, near Veraval port.
7. Nageshwar : Near Dwarka, Gujarat
8. Trimbakeshwar : Near Nashik, Maharashtra. Marks the starting of the Godavari River
9. Bhimashankar : Pune district, Maharashtra — in the Sahyadri (Western Ghats)
10. Grishneshwar : Near Ellora, Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar (Aurangabad) district, Maharashtra
11. Mallikarjuna : Srisailem, Nallamala Hills, Andhra Pradesh — on the Krishna river. Located within the Nagarjunsagar–Srisailem Tiger Reserve, one of India's largest tiger reserves.
12. Rameshwaram (Ramanathaswamy) : Famed for having the longest corridor of any Hindu temple in India



In Backdrop of Handshake, a Cultural Keynote : Rameshwaram Temple

Which of the following is/are famous for Sun temples?

1. Arasavalli
2. Amarakantak
3. Omkareshwar

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

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1. 1 only
2. 2 and 3 only
3. 1 and 3 only
4. 1, 2 and 3

In Backdrop of Handshake, a Cultural Keynote : Rameshwaram Temple

The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the new Circuit House near Somnath Temple at Veraval. Which of the following statements are correct regarding Somnath Temple?

1. Somnath Temple is one of the Jyotirlinga shrines.
2. A description of Somnath Temple was given by Ali-Biruni.
3. Pran Pratishtha of Somnath Temple (installation of the present day temple) was done by President S. Radhakrishnan.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

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Saudi Shuts Critical East-West Oil Pipeline

Saudi shuts critical East-West oil pipeline

Houthis tighten their control on Red Sea shipping

Mohammed Ghobari,
Eman Abouhassira
& Yasmine Ghania
Aden, Dubai, September 12

SAUDI ARABIA has shut down its East-West pipeline, after the vital oil conduit came under aerial attack in the widening West Asia war, threatening to send energy prices even higher.

The world's largest crude oil exporter said it temporarily closed the pipeline as a precaution after a drone attack that both Baghdad and Riyadh said had originated in Iraq, where Iranian-backed militias operate. Iraq dismissed a military commander on Saturday in response to the attack.

The 1,200-km pipeline running across the Arabian Peninsula has served as the main route out for global supplies of Middle East oil for the past six months while the Strait of Hormuz has been largely shut by war.

It has been moving 4 million to 5 million barrels per day, amounting to 4% to 5% of global supply, sparing Saudi Arabia the brunt of the disruption that has crippled other Gulf oil and gas exporters.

There was no immediate claim of responsibility for the strikes. Satellite images showed black smoke rising from an area of the pipeline south of Medina. The attack resulted in some injuries and damage that was being assessed, the Saudi Foreign Ministry said without detailing the impact on exports.

US President Donald Trump, visiting Ireland to attend a golf tournament at one of his resorts, said Iran was probably to blame.



Houthi fighters raise slogans atop a military vehicle in Dhubbab district, Taiz province. (Right) Satellite image shows damage to the East-West pipeline facility in the Hejaz Region, Saudi Arabia. AP/REUTERS

Oil prices shot up over the past week and the retail price of diesel in the United States surged past a record \$6 a gallon, as the United States and Iran both fired on tankers and the Iran-aligned Houthis in Yemen advanced along the Red Sea, potentially extending disruption to another major oil route.

Saudi Arabia's de facto ruler, Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, phoned Trump on Thursday and asked for U.S. military help fighting the Houthis, three sources told Reuters. They said the prince was told that Washington would not intervene directly for now but would help with intelligence.

Trump confirmed on Saturday that he had spoken to the crown prince, and said the Houthis had also phoned his administration and asked Washington not to become directly involved in the conflict.

Four Yemeni government sources told Reuters that the Houthis had seized the strategic

island of Perim on Friday in the middle of the Bab el-Mandeb Strait — the "Gate of Tears" at the mouth of the Red Sea.

There have been no talks between the United States and Iran to end the conflict since a June agreement that collapsed within weeks.

In a post on X on Saturday, Ebrahim Azizi, head of the Iranian parliament's national security committee, said: "As long as the American side does not accept all of Iran's conditions, dialogue and negotiation are of no use."

Iran's foreign ministry announced on Friday that Iran would be attending a meeting with Gulf Arab states in Oman on Monday, at which the future of the Strait of Hormuz would be discussed.

But a senior Iranian official, speaking to Reuters on condition of anonymity on Saturday, played down the chances of a breakthrough, saying the meeting, called at Oman's initiative,



was intended to discuss issues including the strait but was not expected to yield a signed agreement.

An agreement on routes through the Strait of Hormuz between Iran and Oman will be presented at the meeting on Monday, which will also be attended by Iraq, but the strait will not reopen unless seven conditions conveyed by Iran to the US are met, a source told *Tasnim* news agency, without elaborating.

Oman has not officially announced the meeting, and other Gulf countries have remained silent. Bahrain said on

Saturday it would not attend meetings with Iran.

The apparent launch of the attack on the Saudi pipeline from Iraq puts additional pressure on the Baghdad government, which is unique in the region for maintaining close political and military ties with both the United States and Iran.

Iraq dismissed the military commander and police chief in Maysan province near the Iranian frontier, long regarded as an area where Iran-backed Shi'ite militias operate and maintain influence, and shut the main border crossing there. REUTERS

Iran probably responsible for attack on Saudi pipeline: Trump

Reuters
Dublin, September 12

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Saturday that Iran was probably responsible for an aerial attack on Saudi Arabia that shut down its East-West pipeline, one of the kingdom's main routes for exporting crude while bypassing the Strait of Hormuz.

"I think they are, probably they are," Trump told reporters in Dublin when asked if Iran was responsible for the attack on the vital oil conduit.

The US President also said that he had spoken with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, whom he described as a "good friend."

Trump added that Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis had called his administration and indicated they did not want the United States to become directly involved in the conflict.

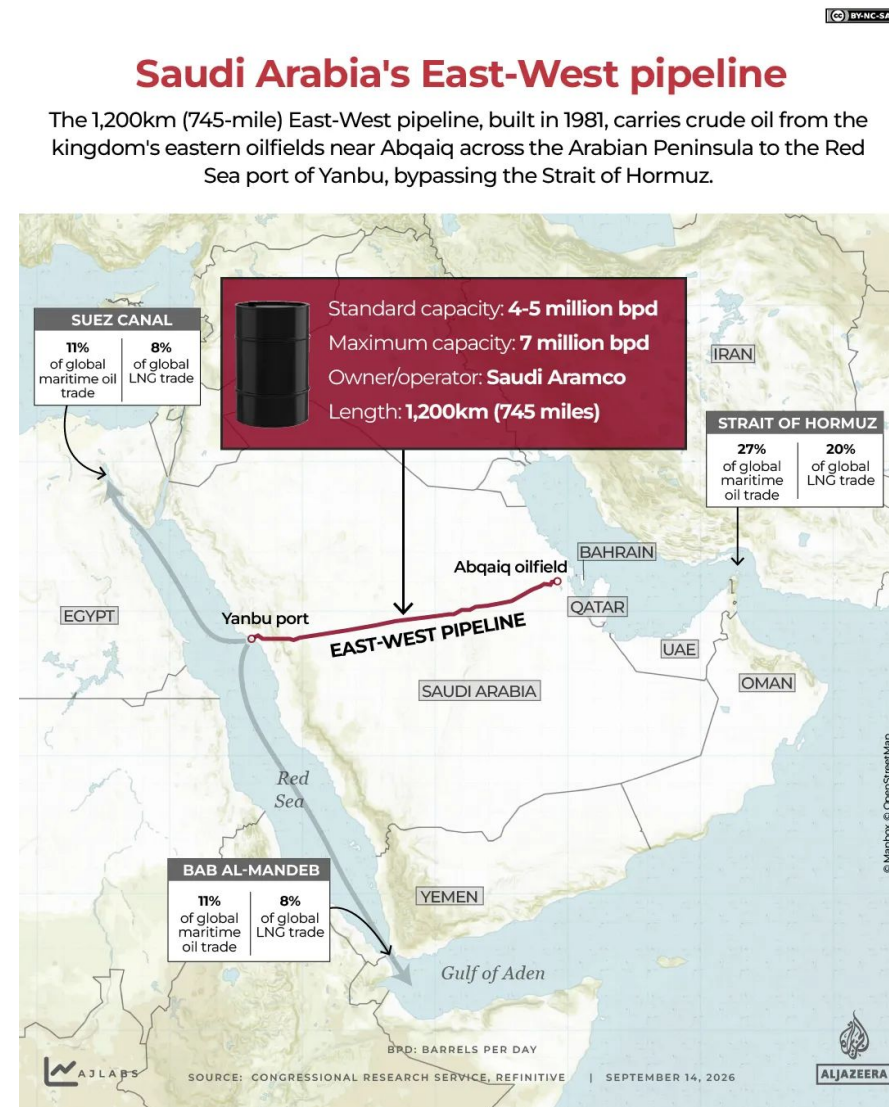
"They would much prefer not having us involved, and they're letting most ships go through. There's just one country that they're not too happy with, and we'll get that straightened out," Trump added.

Iran told the Houthis last week to escalate their attacks on Saudi Arabia and promised more funding, weapons and senior officers to help them do so, two Iranian sources said.

Iran describes the Houthis as an ally but publicly denies giving them military direction, saying they are "not a proxy".

Saudi Shuts Critical East-West Oil Pipeline

- The East–West Pipeline, also known as the Petroline, is a 1,201-kilometre-long (746 mi) pipeline in Saudi Arabia that runs from the Abqaiq oil field in the Eastern Province (near Bahrain and Qatar on the Persian Gulf coast) across the width of the Arabian Peninsula, to Yanbu at the Red Sea. It was built during the Iran–Iraq War in the 1980s to allow Saudi oil exports to bypass the tanker war taking place in the Strait of Hormuz.



Saudi Shuts Critical East-West Oil Pipeline

- The Sumed Pipeline (also known as the Suez-Mediterranean Pipeline) is an oil pipeline in Egypt, running from the Ain Sokhna terminal in the Gulf of Suez, the northernmost terminus of the Red Sea, to offshore Sidi Kerir port, Alexandria In the Mediterranean Sea. It provides an alternative to the Suez Canal for transporting oil from the Persian Gulf region to the Mediterranean.



Saudi Shuts Critical East-West Oil Pipeline

Consider the following statements :

Statement-I: Sumed pipeline is a strategic route for Persian Gulf oil and natural gas shipments to Europe.

Statement-II: Sumed pipeline connects the Red Sea with the Mediterranean Sea.

Which one of the following is correct in respect of the above statements?

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Studies Official Paper

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1. Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II explains Statement-I
2. Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct, but Statement-II does not explain Statement-I
3. Statement-I is correct, but Statement-II is incorrect
4. Statement-I is incorrect, but Statement-II is correct

Why India's Schools Should Take Note of New York's AI Ban

Why India's schools should take note of New York's AI ban

John Xavier

New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani and Schools Chancellor Kamar H. Samuels, on September 2, unveiled sweeping curbs on AI use and screen time in the city's public schools. As part of the policy, student-facing AI tools are now barred, for a year, for students from kindergarten through eighth grade. The new policy will impact over 600,000 students in one of the largest public school systems in the U.S.

Rather than leaning into AI-assisted learning, the city is doubling down on teaching children how these systems work, alongside age-calibrated screen time limits.

As India has no equivalent policy on the use of AI systems in schools, it should pay close attention to what is about to happen in over thousands of public schools in New York City as learning from there could

be a good starting point to formulate policies that nurture learning and curb unnecessary use of gadgets in schools.

Mr. Mamdani's measures come at time when educators around the world are worried about the unchecked rollout of AI technologies in schools even as teenagers are increasing spending more time scrolling social media posts outside school.

India's woes

India's version of that worry is backed by even starker numbers. ASER's 2024 survey found that 82.2% of all children in the age group 14-16 said they know how to operate a smartphone, but only a little over half use it for anything educational, while a clear majority use it mainly for social media.

In urban India, close to half of parents report their children are spending more than three hours a



Rather than leaning into AI-assisted learning, the city is doubling down on teaching children how these systems work. REUTERS



day on social media, video platforms, and gaming.

India is facing a structural problem as teen digital addiction is on the rise. This year's Economic Survey points out this ominous trend, describing it as carrying real economic and social costs.

New York's policy is not a simple on-off switch on

gadgets and AI. It goes after AI chatbots outright, at every grade level, but it also reaches into AI features quietly embedded inside tools schools already use for reading, writing, and math.

For the youngest children, in pre-kindergarten through second grade, the city is effectively removing one-to-one devices from classrooms. Third to fifth graders face a recommended cap of 30 minutes of screen time a day; middle

schoolers, 45 minutes. High schoolers get a narrower carve-out: a small, vetted set of AI tools in pilot programmes, paired with twice-yearly modules on how the technology works, what it gets wrong, and where its limits lie.

To get started on framing a policy in India, the baseline of one-to-one devices must be estimated. This is likely to be low in India when compared to the U.S., where most classrooms are well-resourced with the latest tech.

The device deficit in Indian schools is a blessing in disguise as it enables more qualified educators to teach students essential, foundational subjects like math and science that form the bedrock of modern computing and AI algorithms. Understanding how these systems are built will help students create new technologies rather than simply be passive consumers. As more

teachers join the school system, the ratio of educators to students increases, enabling more qualitative classroom discussions.

Such a change can create better outcomes in schools. But it will only solve one part of the problem – devices in schools. The other aspect is the pervasive use of smartphones by children at home. Spending more time on those devices can cause significant problems in the long run.

The lesson from New York is that any credible response has to be agitated, aimed at embedded AI as much as visible chatbots, backed by a real evaluation mechanism, and built with as much attention to what happens on how the child spends their time past school time. India currently has the worst numbers and the weakest safety net. It should not wait for a crisis in every area before it acts.

Concept

- **The move:** New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani and Schools Chancellor Kamar H. Samuels unveiled sweeping curbs on AI use and screen time in the city's public schools on September 2; student-facing AI tools are barred for a year for students from kindergarten through eighth grade, affecting over 600,000 students.
- **The philosophy:** Rather than leaning into AI-assisted learning, the city is doubling down on teaching children how these systems work, alongside age-calibrated screen-time limits.
- **Not a blanket ban:** The policy isn't a simple on-off switch, it goes after AI chatbots outright at every grade level, but also reaches into AI features quietly embedded inside tools schools already use for reading, writing and math.
- **Age-tiered rules:** Pre-K to second grade sees one-to-one devices effectively removed from classrooms; third to fifth graders face a recommended cap of 30 minutes of screen time a day; middle schoolers get 45 minutes; high schoolers get a narrow carve-out, a small, vetted set of AI tools in pilot programmes, paired with twice-yearly modules on how the technology works, what it gets wrong, and where its limits lie.
- **India's starker numbers:** India has no equivalent policy on AI use in schools; ASER 2024 found 82.2% of children aged 14-16 know how to operate a smartphone, but only a little over half use it for anything educational, with a clear majority using it mainly for social media.
- **A flagged structural problem:** This year's Economic Survey described rising teen digital addiction as carrying real economic and social costs; in urban India, close to half of parents report their children spending more than three hours a day on social media, video platforms and gaming.
- **India's device deficit as a blessing:** Unlike well-resourced US classrooms, India's shortage of one-to-one devices in schools enables more qualified educators to teach essential foundational subjects like math and science that underpin modern computing and AI, rather than students becoming passive consumers of technology; as more teachers join the system, the educator-to-student ratio improves, enabling richer classroom discussion.
- **The lesson for India:** A credible response has to be age-tiered, aimed at embedded AI as much as visible chatbots, backed by a real evaluation mechanism, and attentive to how children spend their time after school as much as during it, India currently has the worst numbers and the weakest safety net, and shouldn't wait for a crisis to act.

Why Is NCPCR Investigating Meta, Instagram?

Why is NCPCR investigating Meta, Instagram?

What did a BBC investigation show? Why is child sexual exploitation and abuse material appearing on Instagram? Under what powers can the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights summon social media platforms and other companies?

Aroon Deep

The story so far:

Following an investigation by British public broadcaster BBC, which found that Instagram was running paid advertisements promoting child sexual exploitation and abuse material (CSEAM) in India, the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) summoned Meta officials for a hearing on September 9. The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) has also summoned the company on the issue.

What did the BBC investigation show?

In July, BBC created a test account and found that dozens of ads were promoting CSEAM on Instagram. The distribution of CSEAM is a criminal offence in India.

Meta's policy also states that ads must not contain content that sexually exploits children. Meta said in a statement, "Before these cases were brought to our attention, our enforcement

While social media platforms prohibit CSEAM, automatic moderation systems that use some AI to detect unlawful media are not able to catch every violative submission

systems had already identified and disabled several of the violating ads and the accounts behind them." The company said that it automatically removes millions of CSEAM posting accounts each year, but that "no system is perfect and that determined criminals will continue to try to exploit our platform".

This month, the Tech Transparency Project (TTP), a U.S.-based nonprofit, also reported that it found hundreds of CSEAM ads on Facebook and Instagram, including some served to India.

Why are CSEAM ads appearing on Instagram?

While social media platforms prohibit CSEAM, automatic moderation systems that use some AI to detect unlawful media are not able to catch every violative submission. TTP said that Meta's efforts were not enough even within the scope of what it could do. The nonprofit said that, even in cases where Meta did take down CSEAM, it sometimes classified the ads as adult sexual content, potentially "undercounting instances of child sexual abuse".

While Meta revised this information for ads reported by TTP, it "did not fix the flow of child exploitation content in its advertising system" and continued to show CSEAM ads to certain audiences, the nonprofit said. One of the ads appeared to feature an unidentified "underaged European royal," TTP said.

Even when a human reported CSEAM posts, action was not guaranteed, TTP found. "With 57% (73) of the CSEAM ads reported to Meta, the company sent back a message that said, 'We've taken a look and found that this ad doesn't go against our Advertising Standards,'" TTP said.

What was the NCPCR's reaction to the report?

NCPCR issued a notice on July 3, the same day the BBC report came out, demanding an explanation from the company. MeitY also

sought an explanation from Meta.

Shortly after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's July 23 video message to the Indian youth was briefly removed from Facebook due to an "error," MeitY summoned Meta's global public affairs director, Joel Kaplan, to demand an explanation for that removal. The BBC's report was also discussed during that meeting. The government's summons came as it sent a large number of takedown notices over Instagram posts about the Jantar Mantar protests, while footage of the protests and the ensuing police crackdown went viral.

Meta provided written responses to both MeitY and NCPCR. The latter declined a Right to Information request by *The Hindu* for a copy of the company's response, arguing that providing this information would impede its investigation.

After the written response, Meta officials were summoned by NCPCR this month. Neither side provided a description of the meeting.

What powers does NCPCR have to conduct an inquiry like this?

Like the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), the NCPCR's founding law, the Commissions for Protection of Child Rights Act, 2005, gives the body the powers of a civil court under the Criminal Procedure Code (replaced by the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023).

As such, it has the statutory power to demand explanations on issues of child safety from private organisations and can demand reports from law enforcement. NCPCR's remit includes "matters relating to children in need of special care and protection, including children in distress, marginalised and disadvantaged children, children in conflict with law, juveniles, children without family, and children of prisoners, and recommend appropriate remedial measures," and to "[i]nquire into complaints [relating to] non-implementation of laws providing for protection and development of children," the commission said.

NCPCR has in the past issued notices to companies such as Netflix in response to the show *Bombay Begums*, and to Bournvita maker Mondelez over sugar content in their malt powder.



The new Instagram logo. REUTERS

Concept

Just Rights for Children Alliance v. S Harish

- Terminology Child Pornography was replaced with CSAEM (Child Sexual Abuse and Exploitation Material)
- Overturning a previous Madras High Court ruling, the apex court clarified that even passive viewing, browsing, or possessing such material without intent to transmit attracts criminal liability under Section 15 of the POCSO Act and Section 67B of the IT Act.

Four Agricultural Initiatives Announced, Aimed at Climate Resilience

Four agricultural initiatives announced, aimed at climate resilience, productivity

Harikishan Sharma

New Delhi, September 12

THE BRICS nations on Saturday announced four new agriculture initiatives, including the establishment of Agroecology and Regenerative Agriculture for Climate Resilience and Productivity and Digital Agriculture.

In a significant breakthrough for India, the BRICS grouping adopted the New Delhi joint declaration with consensus, in which the leaders also agreed to the establishment of a collaborative, non-binding, and farmer-centric BRICS AGRIN (Agro-Inputs, Genetic Resources, and In-

• 4 AGRI INITIATIVES

BRICS AGRIN (Agro-Inputs, Genetic Resources, and Information Network)

GLOBAL FORUM on Farmers' Rights in Seed Systems

BRICS NETWORK of Centres of Excellence on Agroecology and Regenerative Agriculture for Climate Resilience and Productivity

BRICS NETWORK on Digital Agriculture, including agroforestry, fisheries, and aquaculture

formation Network), while welcoming the launch of a Global Forum on Farmers' Rights in Seed Systems.

"We welcome the outcomes of the 16th BRICS Agriculture Ministers' Meeting, held in Indore. We agree to the establishment of a collaborative, non-binding, and farmer-centric BRICS AGRIN (Agro-Inputs, Genetic Resources, and Information Network), drawing upon relevant national, regional, and international practices. We also welcome the launch of a Global Forum on Farmers' Rights in Seed Systems to address shared challenges, promote effective policies, and encourage the documentation and exchange of traditional knowledge related to agriculture and seed systems," the New Delhi Dec-

laration stated.

It also welcomed the strengthening of cooperation in agriculture through the establishment of a BRICS Network of Centres of Excellence on Agroecology and Regenerative Agriculture for Climate Resilience and Productivity, and a BRICS Network on Digital Agriculture, including agroforestry, fisheries, and aquaculture. We also encourage further cooperation under the BRICS Dialogue on Development of Fisheries and Aquaculture, it said.

The BRICS nation also reiterated their commitment to advancing agriculture negotiations at the WTO.

Concept

- **BRICS Grain Exchange:** BRICS aims to **launch the Grain Exchange by 2027**. Proposed in **2023** and championed by **Russia**, it seeks to strengthen food security, reduce grain price volatility, and facilitate intra-BRICS trade.
- **BRICS AGRIN (Agro-Inputs, Genetic Resources, and Information Network):** It is a collaborative, voluntary, and farmer-centric cooperation framework established by BRICS nations to strengthen joint efforts in seeds, germplasm, and agricultural inputs.
 - India showcased its culinary diplomacy by serving Gucci Marmik, featuring rare **Himalayan Guccchi mushrooms**. Delegates were also given **Koraput coffee from Odisha**, promoting Vocal for Local and grassroots economic empowerment.
- **Global Forum on Farmers' Rights in Seed Systems:** A platform dedicated to protecting farmers' rights, preserving **traditional agricultural knowledge**, and **addressing shared seed system challenges**.
- **Centres of Excellence on Agroecology & Regenerative Agriculture:** A network established to promote natural and sustainable farming practices for climate resilience and productivity.
- **BRICS Network on Digital Agriculture:** A tech-focused initiative to scale modern digital solutions across agriculture, agroforestry, fisheries, and aquaculture.

BRICS Countries Adopt New Delhi Declaration

BRICS countries adopt New Delhi Declaration

Last-minute compromise on language about war in West Asia enables a consensus in the grouping; declaration calls for 'maximum restraint' in war with no specific mention of strikes, rebukes Israel

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India forged a consensus of BRICS countries on Saturday, after Iran and the United Arab Emirates agreed to a last-minute compromise on the language used about the war in West Asia, allowing the 11-member grouping to adopt the New Delhi Declaration at a meeting chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The statement, which did not directly mention the attacks against Iran by the United States and Israel nor Iran's subsequent strikes on its Persian Gulf neighbours, including the UAE, called for "maximum restraint" in the war. It made no separate mention of the Russian war in Ukraine.

Common ground

The New Delhi Declaration adopted at the 18th BRICS summit reaffirmed members' commitment to the bloc's spirit of mutual respect, sovereign equality, and democracy

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- Iran, UAE **back down** from tough positions as text on West Asia **omits direct references** to U.S.-Israel attack on Iran and Iran attack on UAE

- Support for Palestinian state and strong **8-para criticism** of Israel for strikes on Gaza and Lebanon, and displacement of Palestinians

- It condemns imposition of **unilateral coercive measures** like tariffs and sanctions

- Call for comprehensive reform of UN, support for **greater role** for Brazil, India in UNSC

- Support for BRICS trade mechanisms, including **intra-BRICS payments** through national currencies



- It strongly **condemns terrorism** in all forms, including the 2025 Pahalgam attack

The meeting was attended by the leaders of eight member countries, including Russian President Vladimir Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, and the leaders of Indonesia, Ethiopia, Egypt, and South Africa. Brazil

and the UAE sent high-level representatives.

Significantly, given India's close ties with Israel and Mr. Modi's own visit to Jerusalem in February, the grouping declared its strong criticism of the country for its bombardment of Gaza. It expressed

support for South Africa's case against Israel in international courts, calling for the provision of humanitarian aid in Gaza.

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DETAILED COVERAGE ON

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Thank You